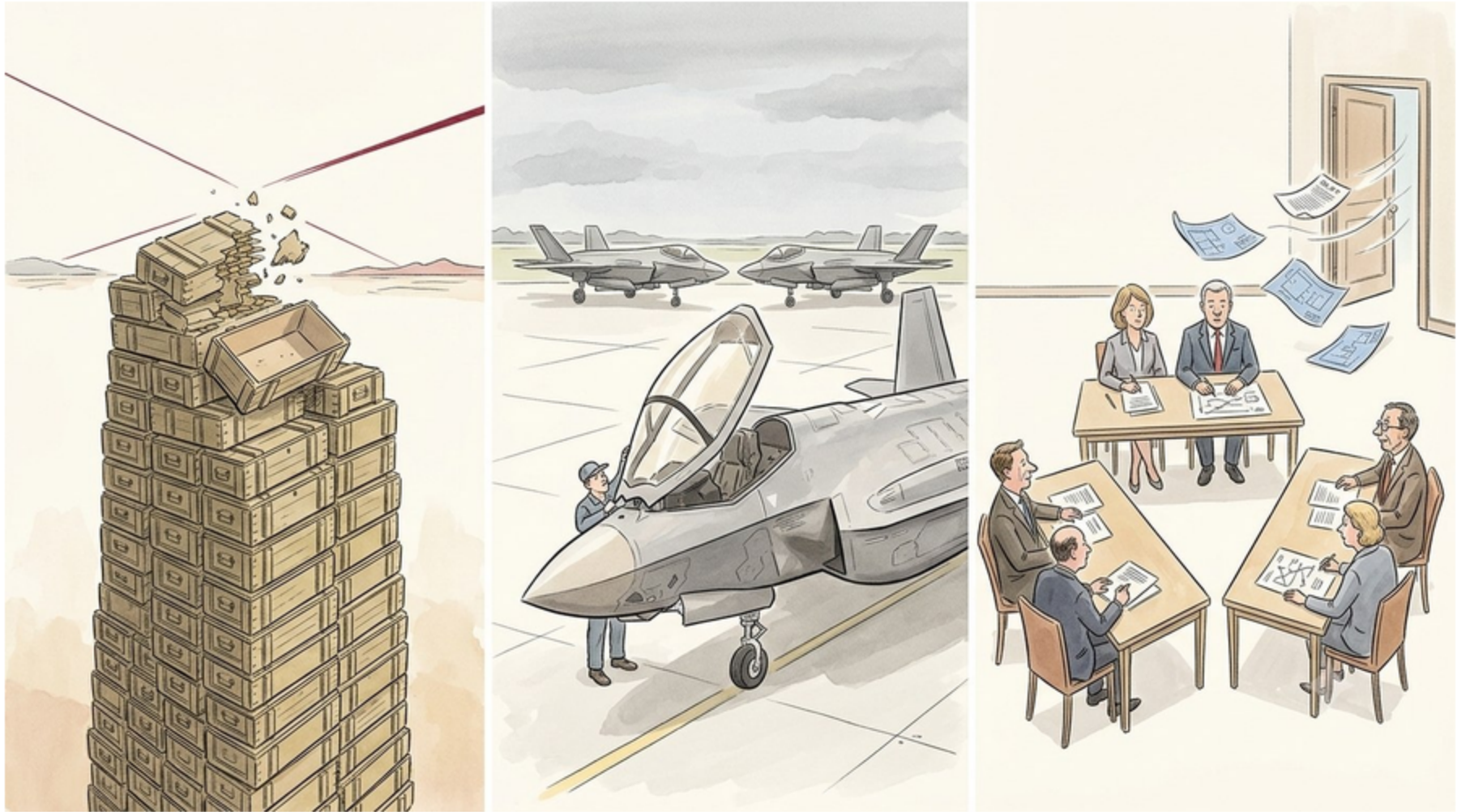


FRONTION NEWS

Defense Brief

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July 13, 2026



US Weapons Stockpiles Strained, F-35 Readiness Hits Record Low, and Europe's Fighter Future Splinters

The Bottom Line

This week's defense landscape is defined by the strain between ambition and capacity. The US F-35 fleet — the most expensive weapon program in history at \$1.6 trillion — can only field a quarter of its jets fully mission-capable, while depleted munitions stockpiles face fresh demand from the Iran conflict. Europe's fighter future has fractured with FCAS's collapse, and the NATO Ankara summit formalized a burden-shifting that will redefine alliance defense spending regardless of who occupies the White House. Meanwhile, new procurement patterns are emerging: India negotiating BrahMos sales to the UAE, Taiwan firing HIMARS toward China, and Ukraine seeking to produce Patriot missiles under license. The common thread is that established defense supply chains and industrial partnerships are being tested — and in many cases, reconfigured — faster than the institutions managing them can adapt.